

# Navigating EU's Technological Dilemmas: Embracing the case for a European Digital Grand Strategy

🕒 20 Novembre 2024, 15:00 – 18:00, Berlin time (CET, UTC+1)

In an increasingly tech-driven world, Europe wants to impose its voice among the global leaders in the field. To secure a technological influence, much work has already been done at the European level, focusing mainly on the concept of European technological sovereignty (ETS), in tandem with European strategic autonomy (ESA). However, to effectively compete with digital giants such as the US and China, the new EU mandate should go beyond these concepts only, designing an all-encompassing strategy for tech-related policies.

For this reason, in October 2024 ECFR published a [Policy Brief](#) articulating a roadmap for a European digital grand strategy, based on three main dilemmas to overcome: innovation, economic security, and global influence. Can the EU turn these hurdles into strengths to maximize its technological progress? How are these “limits to overcome” perceived and outreached by the national policymaking of EU countries, as well as by the business sphere?

This workshop aims at discussing how a European digital grand strategy can be seen and embraced by different policymakers and stakeholders. Particular attention is devoted to two of the three EU dilemmas: boosting innovation without lacking in regulation and increasing global influence, considering the challenges related to cybersecurity, AI, and hybrid threats.

To this end, the workshop brings together ECFR experts, decision-makers, private sector representatives, and researchers for a closed-door discussion, which takes place in English (no simultaneous translation) under Chatham House Rule.

## Agenda

**15:00-15:20: Arrival of participants and Welcome coffee**

**15:20:15:30:** Welcome remarks

**15:30-15:45: Presentation of the ECFR Policy Brief “Control-Alt-Deliver: A digital grand strategy for the European Union”** – by **Dr. José Ignacio Torreblanca**, Head of Madrid office and Senior Policy Fellow, ECFR; **Giorgos Verdi**, Tech Policy Fellow, ECFR

**15:45-16:45: Panel 1: innovation and regulation, frenemies for real? The new EU digital mandate and the struggle for a regulated innovation**

*The regulatory framework has been one of the pillars of the tech work in the last mandate of the EU, which also became the world's first to regulate fast-emerging fields with the adoption of the EU AI Act. However, a strict normative system also has a downside, being often seen as a brake on innovation and competitiveness by member states and European companies, as also stated in Mario Draghi's recent report on competitiveness. Does rigid regulation really close the door to innovative potential? Can a balance to achieve a fair regulated innovation be struck? How can the new EU mandate facilitate this goal without reducing normative standards?*

Speakers: **Giorgia Abeltino**, Senior Director Government Affairs and Public Policy South Europe, Google; ECFR Council Member; **Giulia Pastorella**, Member of the Italian Chamber of Deputies; **Álvaro Schweinfurth**, Deputy Director for Foreign Policy and Multilateral Relations, CEOE; **Dr. José Ignacio Torreblanca**, Head of Madrid office and Senior Policy Fellow, ECFR

Chair: **Giorgio Rutelli**, Deputy Editor-in-Chief, Adnkronos; ECFR Council Member

**16:45-17:45: Panel 2: Cyber, AI, and hybrid threats. New ambitions, old challenges**

*Countering cyber and hybrid threats is part of the multifaceted playing field in which today's global technological competition takes place. The geopolitical frenzy of recent years, characterized by “traditional and non-traditional” wars and the emergence of new actors, official and informal, has at the same time fostered the proliferation of new forms of cyber and hybrid threats, which AI advancement has made even more threatening and difficult to manage. In an EU digital grand strategy, what room is there for managing these threats? How can the new EU term better address these challenges interconnected and boost the cyber resilience of the Union amid growing global influence?*

Speakers: **Michele Giacomelli**, Special Envoy for Cybersecurity and Head of the Unit for Technological Innovation and Cybersecurity, Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation of Italy; **Anushka Kaushik**, Senior Research Fellow and Cyber Lead, GLOBSEC; **Cristina Vanberghen**, Visiting Fellow, European University Institute; **Olesya Vinhas de Souza**, Defense Analyst, Nato Defense College

Chair: **Giorgio Rutelli**, Deputy Editor-in-Chief, Adnkronos; ECFR Council Member

**17:45-18:00:** Wrap up and conclusions

**18:00-19:00:** Networking drinks

